



Flourish At Home Newsletter

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The Power of Staying Connected

Joseph Coleman



As life changes, maintaining our connections with friends, family, and our communities can become more difficult. With these changes, comes a possible disruption in our day-to-day life; that can be a blessing sometimes. But the unknown is daunting. Particularly during pivotal moments in life—like graduating college, leaving a longtime job, or transitioning into retirement.

Moments of great change present opportunities to distance oneself from a period of turbulence or stress during study, employment, or other long-term structures in life. But they can also impact the routines and relationships that have consequentially formed from these rituals. For those entering retirement, this can become especially apparent. It often becomes harder with age to keep visiting the friends and family we've made once retirement begins.

Fortunately, organizations such as the **Massachusetts Councils on Aging (MCOA)** and its local branches help older adults remain active, informed, and connected. The Massachusetts Council of Aging helps coordinate local councils in your region towards positive care. Local councils, in turn, connect residents with services, programs, and opportunities that support independence and quality of life.

At the local level, the Council on Aging may provide a variety of services including:

- **Transport:** Transportation assistance can help older adults to reach certain locations such as the supermarket, post office, pharmacy, and so forth, to ensure they maintain involvement in their communities.
- **Nutrition:** Meal programs, food delivery, and other nutrition services can help residents access healthy food, particularly for those who cannot easily make trips to the supermarket or access food on their own.
- **Health and Fitness:** The Council on Aging may support programs or help to staff organizations that provide wellness programs, health screening, exercise, or offer health spaces for elders.
- **Insurance Counseling:** One of the most important responsibilities that the Council on Aging undertakes is to provide support and counsel on Medicare and related coverage so that older adults with chronic conditions or other medically related problems can find and better understand the kind of coverage they need. In particular, the Council on Aging may liaise with SHINE Counselors to assist older adults. SHINE stands for Serving the Health Insurance Needs of Everyone, a program which provides free one-to-one

help for Massachusetts residents with Medicare.

- **Social Connection:** Organizing social activities are important work for many Councils on Aging. Be it through puzzles, music, exercise classes, discussion groups, clubs, and community events, the Council of Aging strives to provide environments where older adults can maintain existing friendships and build new ones.
- **Provide General Information and Referrals:** There are many kinds of information that might be useful for those who are aging or nearing retirement. Information such as housing or homecare, as well as knowledge of your eligibility for benefits, are all provided by the Council on Aging.
- **Caregiver Support:** For seniors with a caregiver, the Council on Aging extends the same help to caregivers as well and ensures that both seniors and caregivers have access to support or assistance from friends, family, and qualified volunteers.

Remember, career retirement does not mean retirement from your community. Many resources exist to help adults approaching retirement to stay in touch. Rest assured, organizations and communities exist to ensure that aging doesn't leave out human connections.



A Word About Aging Geriatrician

A geriatrician is a doctor who specializes in the care of older adults. Gerontology, by contrast, is the broader study of aging.

The term geriatrics was coined in 1909 by Ignatz Nascher, an Austrian-born American physician. It helped establish the idea that old age deserved its own medical

expertise rather than being treated simply as an unavoidable decline.

Today, nearly one in five Americans is over 65, yet there are fewer than 7,000 geriatricians in the country—roughly one for every 10,000 older adults.

One reason is financial. Geriatrics generally pays less than many other medical specialties, partly because so many older patients rely on Medicare.

As the baby-boom generation ages, geriatricians are increasingly important. Unfortunately, we appear to be producing older adults far faster than we are producing the doctors trained to care for them.

Source:
NIH Library
[washingtonpost.com/health/2024/03/17/](https://www.washingtonpost.com/health/2024/03/17/)



Flourish At Home Newsletter

This is the first in what I hope will become a series of newsletters about aging—with a small twist. I am inviting young adults to write about what it means to grow older.

One of the aims of Flourish At Home is to create a platform for emerging writers and artists to develop their work and find an audience. It is a small way of helping nurture young talent while bringing generations into conversation with one another.

Social work is, at its heart, about helping people live fuller and more vibrant lives. Creating opportunities for younger adults feels like an extension of that same idea.

I hope these newsletters will explore the many dimensions of growing older— independence, friendship, creativity, memory, health, purpose, and the

complicated business of staying engaged
with life

Please send us your thoughts and
suggestions for future themes. After all,
flourishing is easier with a little
constructive feedback.

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